



Wat Rong Khun

A privately owned temple, art exhibit, and center of Buddhist learning and meditation



The original Buddhist temple of Wat Rong Khun, in the northernmost Chiang Rai province of Thailand, fell into disrepair during the late 20th century. A local artist, Chalermchai Kositpipat (1955–), decided to rebuild the temple from scratch, funding the work with his own money. To date, he has spent 1,080 million Thai baht (around \$34 million) on the ongoing project, which is not expected to be completed until 2070 at the earliest. The temple opened to the public in 1997; admission is free for Thais, and only small offerings are accepted because Chalermchai refuses to be influenced by big donors.

White and gold

When completed, the temple—popularly known as the White Temple—will consist of nine buildings, including the existing *ubosot*, or prayer room, where ordinations take place; a meditation hall; a hall of relics; an art gallery; and living quarters for monks. The architecture is elaborate and ornate, much of it

including elements from classic Thai buildings. While the *ubosot* is pure white with fragments of mirrored glass embedded in its exterior and represents the mind, the building housing the restrooms is golden, symbolizing how people focus on worldly desires.

Unusually for a Buddhist temple, the design, while based on classic Thai architecture, also includes depictions of western idols such as Michael Jackson, Freddy Krueger, and Neo from *The Matrix*, as well as controversial images of nuclear warfare, 9/11, and oil wells.

▷ GUARDING THE TEMPLE

Fierce guardian statues embedded with small mirror mosaics protect the entrance to the White Temple.

